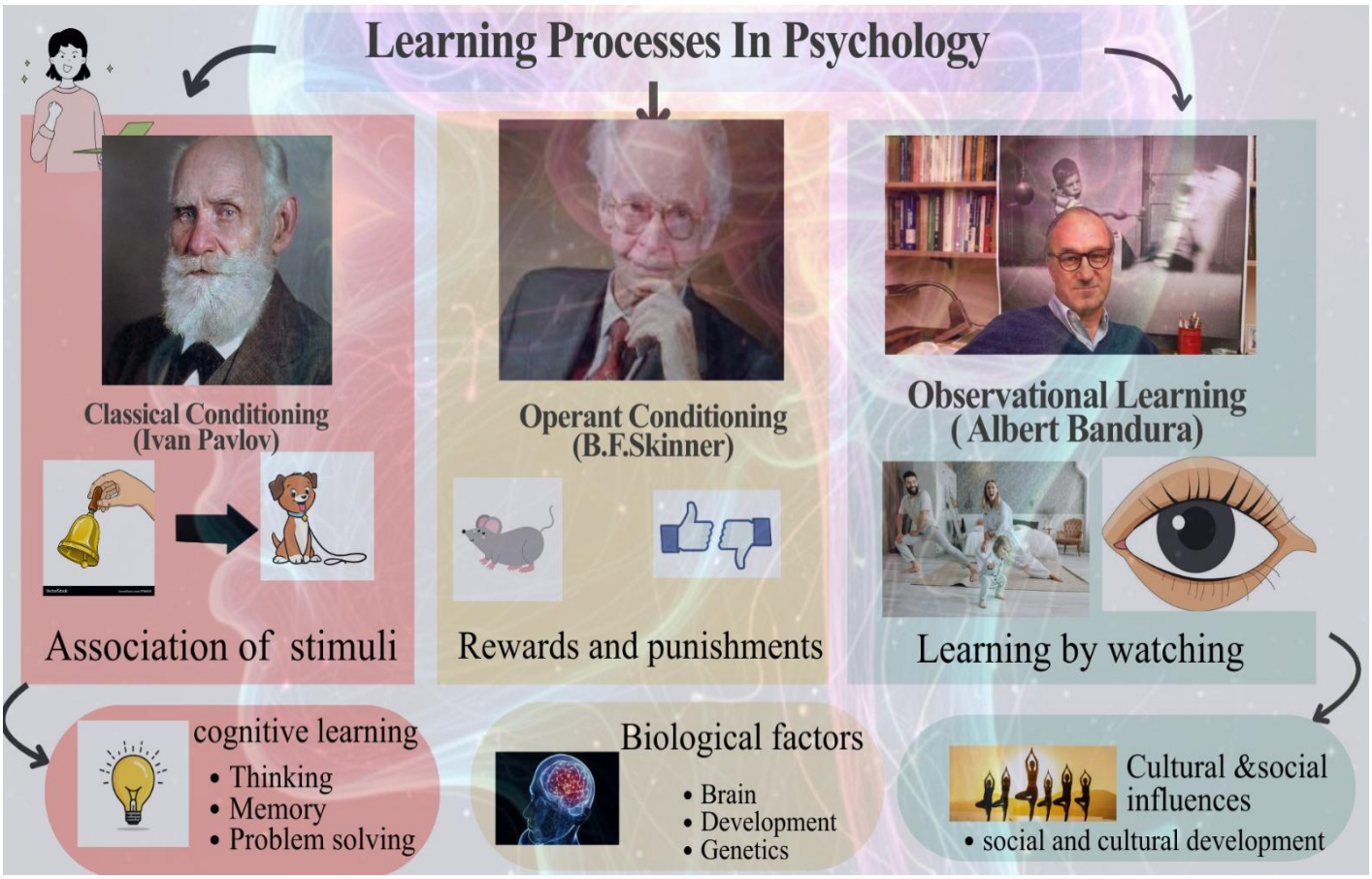
THE OPEN UNIVERSITY OF SRI LANKA

FACULTY OF HEALTH SCIENCES

DEPARTMENT OF PSYCHOLOGY & COUNSELLING

PLU 3301 Introduction to Psychology

Continuous Assessment Test II (CATII)



Name: Sachini Nadeesha Nethsarani

Registration Number: 525772803

Program: BSc. (Hons) in Psychology

Academic Year: 2025/2026-Semester I

Course Code: PLU3301

Course Title: Introduction to Psychology

Number of pages: 06

Number of words: 228

National Identity Card Number: 200572203435

CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK OF LEARNING PROCESSES.

Introduction

Learning processes in psychology explain how humans acquire new behaviors and knowledge through experience. The main learning processes include classical conditioning, operant conditioning and observational learning, which together provide a comprehensive understanding of learning. Each theory provides a unique perspective of how individuals acquire new behaviors and knowledge.

The first component of the framework is **Classical Conditioning,** a theory introduced by Ivan Pavlov. This process emphasizes the "Association of stimuli", where a neutral stimulus is paired with unconditioned stimulus to elicit a conditioned response. This reflects the most basic form of associative learning, typically illustrated by Pavlov's experiments with salivary responses in dogs. In Pavlov's research, the repetitive pairing of a bell with food eventually caused the dog to salivate at the sound of the bell alone.

The second core element is **Operant Conditioning**, advanced by B.F. Skinner, explains learning through consequences, such as reinforcement and punishments. Positive and negative reinforcement increase the likelihood of a behavior, while punishment decreases it. B.F. Skinner demonstrated this using rats and pigeons, showing that voluntary behavior can be shaped systematically through rewards and consequences.

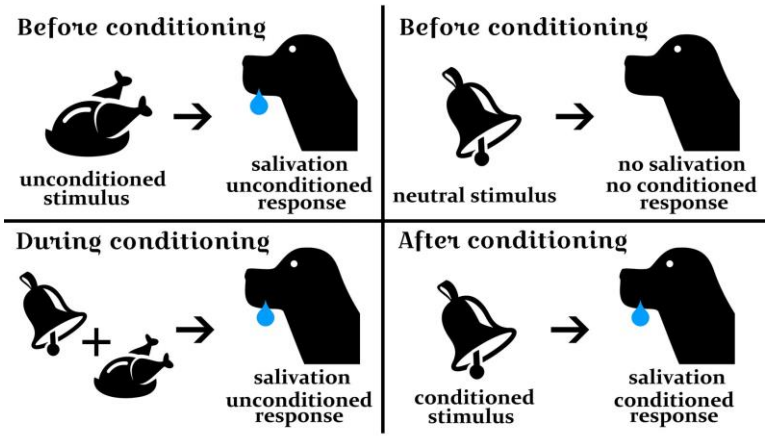
Furthermore, Albert Bandura's **Observational Learning** introduces a crucial cognitive-social dimension. Unlike purely behaviorist models, this theory asserts that learning can occur through imitation and modeling even without immediate reinforcement. This suggests

that internal mental states such as attention and motivation, are essential mediators between environmental stimuli and behavioral output.

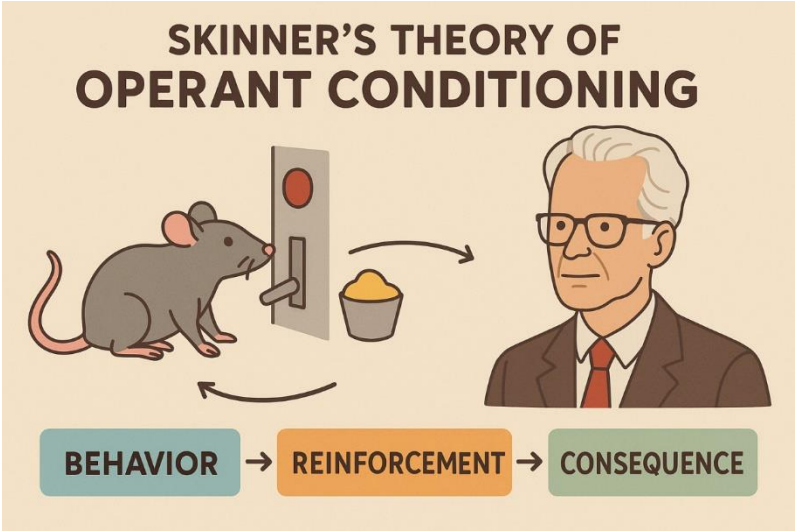
The framework integrates critical influencing factors such as Cognitive processes (thinking and memory), Biological factors (the brain and genetics) and Socio-cultural influences. These elements demonstrate that learning is not merely a mechanical response but a multifaceted phenomenon shaped by internal mental states and external environmental contexts.

Conclusion

These three processes are not mutually exclusive but function as a complementary system. While behaviorist theories provide a solid foundation for understanding basic stimulus-response patterns, cognitive-social theories are necessary to explain the complexities of human learning in social contexts. This holistic framework is vital for psychological interventions and understanding human adaptation across the lifespan.



Ivan Pavlov's experiment



B.F. Skinner's experiment

Bandura's experiment

References

American Psychological Association. (2020). *Publication manual of the American Psychological Association* (7th ed.).

Bandura, A. (1977). *Social learning theory.* Prentice Hall.

Myers, D. G., & DeWall, C. N. (2021). *Psychology* (13th ed.). Worth Publishers.

Pavlov, I. P. (1927). *Conditioned reflexes. An investigation of the physiological activity of the cerebral cortex.* Oxford University Press.

Skinner B.F. (1938).*The behavior of organisms: An experimental analysis.* Appleton-Century.

Tarpy, R. M. (1997*) Contemporary Learning Theory and Research*. McGraw-Hill College.